

Title: *The Last Train to Elmridge*

It was a rainy Friday evening when **Clara Jennings**, a 32-year-old investigative journalist, boarded the **7:45 PM train to Elmridge**. Her editor, **Mark Reynolds**, had called her just an hour ago, asking her to cover a breaking story about a **missing biotech researcher** named **Dr. Ethan Cole**.

Ethan, 41, was a brilliant but secretive scientist working for **Novacore Labs**, a company rumored to be developing a **gene-editing technology** that could potentially **cure several genetic diseases**. Two days ago, he vanished without a trace. His apartment was locked from the inside, and his car was still parked outside. The police had no leads, but Clara had received an **anonymous email** earlier that day containing one cryptic line:

“The answer is hidden in Train Car 4.”

She didn’t know who sent it, but she trusted her instincts.

As the train rattled through the storm, Clara moved to **Car 4**, where she noticed an **older man** sitting alone, reading a book about molecular biology. She hesitated, then sat across from him.

“Are you heading to Elmridge?” she asked casually.

The man looked up, adjusted his glasses, and replied,

“Not exactly. I’m getting off at **Redwood Junction**. But I suppose you’re looking for Ethan Cole, aren’t you?”

Clara froze.

“How do you know about Ethan?”

The man smiled faintly.

“Because he’s my brother.”

Before Clara could ask more, the lights flickered and the train **screeched to an unexpected halt**. The conductor’s voice crackled over the intercom:

“Attention passengers, we’ve encountered a **signal failure** near Redwood Junction. Please remain seated.”

But Clara noticed something strange — several **men in black coats** were moving swiftly through the aisles, whispering into earpieces. One of them briefly made eye contact with her, then touched his wristwatch twice.

The older man leaned closer and whispered,

“Listen carefully. Ethan discovered something dangerous — something Novacore doesn’t want the public to know. They’re not curing diseases... they’re **engineering them**.”

Clara’s heart raced.

“Where’s Ethan now?”

He hesitated, then slid a **small USB drive** across the table.

“Everything you need is on here. But whatever you do, **don’t trust anyone from Novacore**. Not even the police.”

Suddenly, one of the men in black approached and demanded,

“Ma’am, we need you to come with us.”

Clara clutched the USB tightly, realizing she had only two choices:

- Follow them and risk losing the story — or
- Jump off the stalled train into the stormy woods and disappear.

She looked out the window at the dark forest. Somewhere out there, she sensed Ethan was hiding.

And for the first time, she wasn’t sure who the real enemy was — Novacore, the mysterious agents, or even Ethan himself.